

Tricks for better performance

Vista can be demanding, but a few tweaks will make it run smoothly, even on an ageing PC

Here's the scenario: a PC bought in 2003 is to be upgraded from Windows XP to Vista Home Premium. Before upgrading, we downloaded the Vista Upgrade Advisor from www.tinyurl.com/23dq97, which told us that our PC would be able to run Vista Basic but would not support 'the Windows Aero experience' in Vista Home Premium — meaning we wouldn't get Vista's new Desktop look.

If this sounds familiar, upgrading to a cheap Vista-compatible graphics card may well allow you to run Home Premium with all its graphical flourishes. But, depending on your system's configuration, you may find that using the machine is like wading through treacle. Everything may seem to happen a few seconds too late, or hang for longer than expected. In this Workshop, we'll show you how to perk things up.

Tip 1

To reduce the drains that Vista's visual enhancements impose on slower computers, right-click the Windows Desktop and select Personalize. When the 'Personalize appearance and sounds' menu opens, click 'Window Color and Appearance', then remove the tick from the Enable Transparency box. This retains most of Aero's effects but improves its display speed. For an even bigger boost, switch off Aero by clicking the blue link at the bottom of the 'Window Color and Appearance' menu. This opens an Appearance Settings dialogue box like the one in Windows XP. Select Windows Vista Basic and click OK. Gain more speed by turning off special effects. To do so, click Start > Control Panel > System and

